NETI MONTHLY

Clarity, Not Clutter.

APRIL 2026

UPSC Civil Services Examination | GS Paper I, II & III

8 Deep Dives | 20 MCQs | Neti Neti Skip List | Quick-Fire Facts

A NOTE TO THE READER

This magazine covers April 2026 current affairs. Every topic here was selected because it has genuine exam probability — not because it was popular in the news. You will find things missing. That is intentional.

UPSC 2026 Prelims is approximately 6 weeks away. Your goal for this issue: finish it in 5 days, then revisit the Must-Know topics once more before the exam. Do not attempt to memorise everything. Understand the mechanism behind each event and you will handle any question format UPSC throws at it.

SECTION 1 — THE MONTH AT A GLANCE

A complete picture of April 2026 in under 10 minutes. Read this before anything else.

Top 10 Things You MUST Know This Month

1.	Constitution 131st Amendment Bill 2026 — Lok Sabha expansion from 543 to ~888 seats based on 2011 Census; also triggers Women's Reservation Act.
2.	Population Census 2026 commenced April 1 — first since 2011; involves 30 lakh+ officials across India.
3.	Ganga Expressway (594 km) inaugurated — Meerut to Prayagraj, 12 UP districts, ₹36,000 crore, includes 3.5 km emergency airstrip.
4.	India–New Zealand FTA signed — India's most recent bilateral trade deal; covers goods, services, investment, and Indo-Pacific strategic alignment.
5.	UAE exits OPEC+ (effective May 1, 2026) — reshapes global oil supply dynamics; UAE was OPEC's third-largest producer.
6.	DPI@2047 roadmap launched by NITI Aayog — three-phase digital public infrastructure framework for Viksit Bharat.
7.	International Big Cat Alliance (IBCA) — New Delhi Declaration proposed; India positions itself as global biodiversity governance leader.
8.	Exercise Pragati — Indian Army multilateral exercise with 11 Indian Ocean nations; reflects India's expanding IOR security role.
9.	SCO Defence Ministers' Meeting, Bishkek — India's participation amid ongoing geopolitical realignments.
10.	Uniform Civil Code — Madhya Pradesh forms drafting panel; Uttarakhand remains only state to implement UCC; Gujarat bill passed but not notified.

15-Day Reading Calendar

The magazine is built to be read in 15 days at 4–5 pages per day. Stick to this plan. The goal is completion + revision, not a single marathon session.

Days 1–2	Section 1 (Month at a Glance) + Polity Deep Dives (Lok Sabha Bill, Census)
Days 3–4	Economy Deep Dives (Ganga Expressway, UAE/OPEC, DPI@2047)
Days 5–6	IR Deep Dives (India-NZ FTA, SCO) + Environment (IBCA)

Days 7–8	Security + Society + Neti Neti List + Visual Vault
Days 9–10	Previous Month Recall (MCQs) + Stillness Corner
Days 11–12	Monthly Scorecard (20 MCQs) — attempt without notes
Days 13–14	Revisit all MUST-KNOW Exam Focus points only
Day 15	Quick-Fire Facts — read once, slowly

Monthly Mantra: 'You don't need to know everything. You need to know the right things, deeply.'

SECTION 2 — DEEP DIVES

Each topic below is tagged by priority. Spend the most time on MUST-KNOW cards. SHOULD-KNOW and GOOD-TO-KNOW cards need one reading and the MCQ — no more.

POLITY & GOVERNANCE

Constitution 131st Amendment Bill, 2026 — Lok Sabha Expansion

● **MUST-KNOW** GS: GS Paper II (Polity) Prelims ✓ Mains ✓

THE STORY

The Constitution 131st Amendment Bill, 2026 proposes to expand the Lok Sabha from 543 to approximately 888 seats, based on the 2011 Census. The current freeze on seats was imposed after the 1971 Census to avoid penalising states that implemented population control. The 84th Amendment (2001) extended this freeze until the first census after 2026. The bill also triggers the Women's Reservation Act, which mandates 33% seats for women. The move is politically sensitive because northern states with larger populations stand to gain significantly more seats than southern states.

EXAM FOCUS

- Article 81 sets the constitutional cap on Lok Sabha seats (max 550 elected members).
- The 84th Amendment (2001) froze seat numbers until post-2026 census.
- Women's Reservation Act requires 33% reservation — applicable after delimitation.
- North-South divide: states with higher population growth gain more seats.
- State Council seats (Rajya Sabha) not affected — only Lok Sabha.

STATIC BRIDGE

→ *Laxmikanth: Chapter on Parliament → Lok Sabha composition, Article 81*

→ *Delimitation Commission — composition and mandate*

→ *10th Schedule (Anti-Defection) and its relation to seat numbers*

CONTEXT & MAINS ANGLE

The bill has strong political economy implications. Southern states fear reduced influence in a seat-expanded Lok Sabha and potential resource allocation shifts. Constitutional debate centres on whether per-capita representation can override population control incentives. For Mains, analyse: federal equity vs. democratic representation, implications for cooperative federalism, and whether a weighted-votes system (as in the US Senate) could be an alternative.

SELF-TEST

Q. With reference to the Constitution 131st Amendment Bill, 2026, consider the following statements: 1. It proposes to expand the Lok Sabha to approximately 888 seats based on the 2011 Census. 2. Article 81 currently limits the Lok Sabha to a maximum of 600 elected

members. 3. The 84th Amendment extended the seat freeze until the first census after 2026. Which of the above statements is/are correct?

(a) 1 only
(b) 1 and 3 only
(c) 2 and 3 only
(d) 1, 2 and 3

Answer: (b) 1 and 3 only — Article 81 limits to 550, not 600.

Population Census 2026 — India's First Census Since 2011

● **MUST-KNOW** GS: GS Paper II (Governance) Prelims ✓ Mains ✓

THE STORY

India commenced the nationwide Population Census 2026 on April 1. This is the first census since 2011; the 2021 census was postponed due to COVID-19. The exercise involves over 30 lakh (3 million) officials and will be India's 16th population census. The data collected will be used for delimitation, policy planning, welfare scheme targeting, and resource allocation. For the first time, the census includes questions on caste — data on Other Backward Classes (OBC) in particular is expected to have significant political implications for reservation policy.

EXAM FOCUS

- Census is conducted under the Census Act, 1948.
- 15 years gap (2011 to 2026) — longest gap in independent India.
- Caste enumeration included for the first time since 1931.
- Data will be used for delimitation under the 131st Amendment.
- Census Commissioner appointed by the Central Government.

STATIC BRIDGE

→ *Census Act, 1948 — legal framework*

→ *Articles 82 and 170 — delimitation of Lok Sabha and State Assembly seats*

→ *OBC reservation debate — Mandal Commission, 27% cap under Indra Sawhney judgment*

CONTEXT & MAINS ANGLE

The caste enumeration element makes this census politically charged. OBC data could provide a constitutional basis for enhancing reservations beyond current levels — or could invite legal challenges. The linkage between census data and delimitation also means population-growth patterns will reshape India's political map for the next two to three decades.

SELF-TEST

Q. Which of the following is correct regarding the Census Act, 1948? 1. It mandates a decennial census. 2. The Registrar General of India superintends the census. 3. Disclosure

of individual census data is prohibited for 100 years. Select the correct answer using the code below:
(a) 1 and 2 only
(b) 2 and 3 only
(c) 1 and 3 only
(d) 1, 2 and 3
Answer: (b) 2 and 3 only — the Act does not explicitly mandate decennial periodicity.

Uniform Civil Code — Madhya Pradesh Drafting Panel

○ **SHOULD-KNOW** GS: GS Paper II (Polity / Governance) Prelims ✓ Mains ✓

THE STORY

Madhya Pradesh constituted a high-level committee in April 2026 to prepare a draft Bill on the Uniform Civil Code. This follows Uttarakhand, which became the first state to implement the UCC in 2024 and remains the only state to have done so. Gujarat passed a UCC Bill but has not notified it. The Directive Principles (Article 44) call on the state to secure a UCC for citizens, but personal law remains a Concurrent List subject.

EXAM FOCUS

- Article 44 (DPSP) — State shall endeavour to secure a UCC.
- Uttarakhand: first and only state to implement UCC (2024).
- Personal laws (Hindu, Muslim, Christian, Parsi) are Concurrent List subjects.
- SC's Shah Bano judgment (1985) and its political aftermath.
- Parliamentary referral vs. state-level implementation — constitutional question.

STATIC BRIDGE

→ *Laxmikanth: Directive Principles — Article 44*
→ *Concurrent List — Seventh Schedule*
→ *Shah Bano Case (1985), Sarla Mudgal Case — judicial history of UCC*

SELF-TEST

Q. Consider the following statements regarding the Uniform Civil Code: 1. Article 44 of the Constitution places the UCC in the Fundamental Rights chapter. 2. Uttarakhand is the first state to implement the UCC. 3. Personal laws in India are governed by Parliament under the Union List. Which is/are correct?
(a) 2 only
(b) 1 and 2 only
(c) 2 and 3 only
(d) 1, 2 and 3
Answer: (a) 2 only — Article 44 is a DPSP; personal laws are in the Concurrent List.

ECONOMY

Ganga Expressway Inaugurated — 594 km, Meerut to Prayagraj

● **MUST-KNOW** GS: GS Paper III (Infrastructure / Economy) Prelims ✓

THE STORY

Prime Minister Modi inaugurated the Ganga Expressway on April 29, 2026, at Hardoi, Uttar Pradesh. The 594-km access-controlled six-lane expressway connects Meerut to Prayagraj and passes through 12 districts: Meerut, Hapur, Bulandshahr, Amroha, Sambhal, Badaun, Shahjahanpur, Hardoi, Unnao, Raebareli, and Pratapgarh. Built at a cost of over ₹36,000 crore, it includes a 3.5 km emergency airstrip in Shahjahanpur. It is India's longest expressway in a single state.

EXAM FOCUS

- 594 km length — India's longest expressway within a single state.
- 12 districts connected: begins at Meerut, ends at Prayagraj.
- Emergency airstrip: 3.5 km at Shahjahanpur — dual civilian-defence use.
- Cost: over ₹36,000 crore.
- Six-lane, access-controlled (no roadside intersections).

STATIC BRIDGE

→ *National Highways Authority of India (NHAI) — mandate and funding*

→ *Bharatmala Pariyojana — national expressway development programme*

→ *National Infrastructure Pipeline — infrastructure targets*

CONTEXT & MAINS ANGLE

Expressways with emergency airstrips are increasingly important for India's dual-use infrastructure policy — civilian economic connectivity combined with military logistics readiness. The Ganga Expressway corridor passes through eastern UP, historically underdeveloped, and is expected to catalyse industrial investment.

SELF-TEST

Q. Consider the following about the Ganga Expressway: 1. It connects Meerut to Prayagraj. 2. It passes through 15 districts of Uttar Pradesh. 3. It includes a 3.5 km emergency airstrip at Shahjahanpur. Which is/are correct?

(a) 1 and 2 only
(b) 1 and 3 only
(c) 2 and 3 only
(d) 1, 2 and 3

Answer: (b) 1 and 3 only — it passes through 12 districts, not 15.

UAE Exits OPEC+ — Global Oil Market Realignment

● **MUST-KNOW** GS: GS Paper III (Economy) / GS Paper II (IR) Prelims ✓ Mains ✓

THE STORY

The United Arab Emirates announced withdrawal from OPEC and OPEC+ effective May 1, 2026. The UAE was OPEC's third-largest producer and had long sought higher production quotas, arguing its expanded capacity was being artificially constrained. The exit signals growing tensions between founding OPEC members and newer members who entered via OPEC+. For India, the UAE is a major crude oil supplier, and the exit may create short-term supply uncertainty before new bilateral arrangements are formalised.

EXAM FOCUS

- OPEC founded 1960 — Baghdad Conference. Original members: Iran, Iraq, Kuwait, Saudi Arabia, Venezuela.
- OPEC+: expanded grouping including non-OPEC producers (Russia, UAE, Mexico).
- UAE was third-largest producer within OPEC — significant production capacity.
- India-UAE relations: UAE is among India's top 3 crude oil suppliers.
- Petrodollar system — oil trade in USD; UAE exit does not directly challenge this.

STATIC BRIDGE

→ *India's Strategic Petroleum Reserves (SPRs) — three locations, 5.33 MT total capacity*

→ *Energy security in India's foreign policy — diversification strategy*

→ *India's net oil import dependence (~85% of consumption)*

CONTEXT & MAINS ANGLE

The UAE exit could accelerate OPEC's structural decline. Several members have signalled interest in bilateral deals outside the cartel framework. For India, this is an opportunity to negotiate direct long-term contracts with the UAE, potentially denominated in currencies other than USD — relevant to India's de-dollarisation conversations in BRICS and SCO forums.

SELF-TEST

Q. With reference to OPEC, which of the following is/are correct? 1. OPEC was established in 1960 at the Baghdad Conference. 2. Saudi Arabia, Iraq, Kuwait, Iran and Venezuela were the founding members. 3. OPEC+ includes both OPEC members and certain non-OPEC oil-producing countries. Select using the code below:

(a) 1 and 2 only
(b) 2 and 3 only
(c) 1 and 3 only
(d) 1, 2 and 3

Answer: (d) 1, 2 and 3 — all three are correct.

DPI@2047 Roadmap — NITI Aayog's Digital Public Infrastructure Vision

○ **SHOULD-KNOW** GS: GS Paper III (Economy / Governance) Prelims ✓ Mains ✓

THE STORY

NITI Aayog officially launched the DPI@2047 for Viksit Bharat roadmap in April 2026. DPI refers to Digital Public Infrastructure — the foundational digital layer enabling government services, financial inclusion, and economic activity. India's existing DPI stack (Aadhaar, UPI, DigiLocker) is cited as a global model. The DPI@2047 framework envisions three phases: Phase 1 (2026–30) focuses on foundational livelihoods DPI; Phase 2 (2030–40) on productivity-led growth; Phase 3 (2040–47) on global leadership in AI-enabled public systems.

EXAM FOCUS

- India Stack: Aadhaar + UPI + DigiLocker — the foundation of India's DPI.
- DPI@2047: three-phase roadmap for digital inclusion and productivity.
- NITI Aayog's role: policy think-tank, not implementing agency.
- Viksit Bharat 2047 — India's centenary development vision target.
- DPI-based financial inclusion: Jan Dhan-Aadhaar-Mobile (JAM Trinity).

STATIC BRIDGE

→ *JAM Trinity — Jan Dhan, Aadhaar, Mobile*

→ *NITI Aayog vs. Planning Commission — structural differences*

→ *Unified Payments Interface (UPI) — regulatory framework under RBI/NPCI*

SELF-TEST

Q. Consider the following regarding India's Digital Public Infrastructure: 1. UPI is regulated by the Reserve Bank of India. 2. Aadhaar is issued by the Unique Identification Authority of India (UIDAI). 3. DigiLocker is a service under the Ministry of Finance. Which is/are correct?

(a) 1 and 2 only
(b) 2 only
(c) 1 and 3 only
(d) 1, 2 and 3

Answer: (a) 1 and 2 only — DigiLocker is under the Ministry of Electronics and IT, not Finance.

ENVIRONMENT & ECOLOGY

International Big Cat Alliance (IBCA) — New Delhi Declaration

● **MUST-KNOW** GS: GS Paper III (Environment & Ecology) Prelims ✓ Mains ✓

THE STORY

India proposed the New Delhi Declaration at the International Big Cat Alliance (IBCA) summit in April 2026. The IBCA, launched by India in 2023 on the 50th anniversary of Project Tiger, focuses on conservation of seven big cat species: tiger, lion, leopard, snow leopard, cheetah, puma, and jaguar. The alliance currently has 96 range and non-range countries. The New Delhi Declaration aims to establish binding conservation commitments and a global fund for big cat habitat protection.

EXAM FOCUS

- IBCA launched in 2023 — based in India; conservation of 7 big cat species.
- 7 big cats: tiger, lion, leopard, snow leopard, cheetah, puma, jaguar.
- Project Tiger: launched 1973; India has ~75% of world's wild tiger population.
- Cheetah reintroduction — Kuno National Park, Madhya Pradesh.
- New Delhi Declaration: binding commitments + global conservation fund.

STATIC BRIDGE

→ *Wildlife Protection Act, 1972 — Schedules I and II*

→ *Project Tiger (1973) vs. Project Lion (ongoing) — compare and contrast*

→ *CITES — Appendix I (most endangered) listing for tigers and leopards*

→ *IUCN Red List categories — Endangered, Critically Endangered, Vulnerable*

CONTEXT & MAINS ANGLE

India is making a conscious foreign policy move by leading global biodiversity governance through IBCA. This complements India's positioning at CBD (Convention on Biological Diversity) and Kunming-Montreal Global Biodiversity Framework. For Mains: examine India's conservation model as a diplomatic tool and whether IBCA can become a binding multilateral instrument.

SELF-TEST

Q. Consider the following about the International Big Cat Alliance (IBCA): 1. It was launched in 2023 on the occasion of Project Tiger's 50th anniversary. 2. It focuses on conservation of five big cat species. 3. India serves as the host nation for IBCA. Which is/are correct?

(a) 1 and 3 only
(b) 2 and 3 only
(c) 1, 2 and 3
(d) 1 only

Answer: (a) 1 and 3 only — IBCA covers 7 big cat species, not 5.

INTERNATIONAL RELATIONS

India–New Zealand Free Trade Agreement

● **MUST-KNOW** GS: GS Paper II (International Relations) / GS Paper III (Economy) Prelims ✓ Mains ✓

THE STORY

India and New Zealand signed a bilateral Free Trade Agreement in April 2026. This is India's most recent FTA and the first with a South Pacific OECD nation. The agreement covers goods, services, investment, and digital trade. It is significant for India's Indo-Pacific strategy — New Zealand is a member of the Five Eyes intelligence alliance and the Comprehensive and Progressive Agreement for Trans-Pacific Partnership (CPTPP). The deal reflects a shift in India's trade policy from protectionism toward competitive openness.

EXAM FOCUS

- India-NZ FTA covers: goods, services, investment, digital trade.
- New Zealand is part of CPTPP and Five Eyes — strategic alignment angle.
- India's FTA history: ASEAN FTA (2010), South Korea, Japan, UAE CEPA (2022).
- WTO's Most Favoured Nation (MFN) principle — how FTAs relate to it.
- Rules of Origin — key provision in goods FTAs to prevent re-export.

STATIC BRIDGE

→ *WTO framework — GATT, TRIPS, GATS*

→ *India's CPTPP membership debate — should India join?*

→ *India-UK FTA (ongoing negotiations) — compare approach*

→ *Five Eyes alliance — what it covers, India's observer status*

CONTEXT & MAINS ANGLE

India has traditionally been cautious about FTAs, fearing domestic industry exposure. The NZ FTA signals a more confident approach. New Zealand's dairy sector may benefit, which will draw opposition from India's milk cooperative sector (Amul). For Mains: analyse India's FTA strategy as economic diplomacy and the tension between farm sector protection and export-led growth.

SELF-TEST

Q. With reference to Free Trade Agreements, consider: 1. The WTO's MFN principle requires that trade concessions given to one member be extended to all members, but FTAs are exempted under Article XXIV of GATT. 2. India signed a Comprehensive Economic Partnership Agreement with UAE in 2022. 3. New Zealand is a member of the Comprehensive and Progressive Agreement for Trans-Pacific Partnership (CPTPP). Which is/are correct?

(a) 2 and 3 only
(b) 1 and 2 only
(c) 1 and 3 only

(d) 1, 2 and 3
Answer: (d) 1, 2 and 3 — all three are correct.

SCO Defence Ministers' Meeting — Bishkek, April 2026

○ **SHOULD-KNOW** GS: GS Paper II (International Relations) Prelims ✓

THE STORY

The Shanghai Cooperation Organisation (SCO) Defence Ministers' Meeting was held in Bishkek, Kyrgyzstan on April 28, 2026. India participated alongside China, Russia, Pakistan, Central Asian republics, Iran, and Belarus. The SCO has become India's key platform for engaging with Eurasian powers despite India-Pakistan and India-China tensions within the bloc. Defence cooperation, counter-terrorism, and regional stability were the primary agenda items.

EXAM FOCUS

- SCO founded: 2001 — Shanghai; original members: China, Russia, Kazakhstan, Kyrgyzstan, Tajikistan, Uzbekistan.
- India and Pakistan joined SCO in 2017. Iran joined 2023. Belarus joined 2024.
- SCO Secretariat: Beijing. Regional Anti-Terrorist Structure (RATS): Tashkent.
- India has engaged selectively — participates in SCO but not in CSTO (military wing).
- SCO covers ~40% of world's population, ~30% of global GDP.

STATIC BRIDGE

→ *BRICS vs. SCO — compare composition, mandate, India's role*

→ *CSTO (Collective Security Treaty Organisation) — India not a member*

→ *India's Act East, Connect Central Asia policies*

SELF-TEST

Q. Consider these statements about the SCO: 1. India became a full member of the SCO in 2017. 2. The SCO's Regional Anti-Terrorist Structure (RATS) is headquartered in Tashkent. 3. India is also a member of the Collective Security Treaty Organisation (CSTO). Which is/are correct?

(a) 1 only
(b) 1 and 2 only
(c) 2 and 3 only
(d) 1, 2 and 3
Answer: (b) 1 and 2 only — India is not a member of CSTO.

SECTION 3 — THE NETI NETI LIST: What to Skip This Month

These topics were heavily covered in April 2026 media. They have very low UPSC probability. Time spent here is time taken from what matters.

Topic	Why You Can Skip It
IPL 2026 match results and team standings	*UPSC has never tested cricket tournament outcomes in GS Paper I.*
Day-to-day stock market movements (Sensex, Nifty fluctuations)	*UPSC tests economic concepts and policy, not market tickers.*
State election campaign rhetoric and polling predictions	*Governance and policy tested; electoral politics narrative is not.*
Celebrity appointments to cultural bodies	*Only if constitutional or statutory appointment — these are neither.*
Bilateral meetings where no agreement was signed	*Only substantive outcomes (treaties, frameworks, funding deals) matter.*
Minor administrative reshuffles in central ministries	*Relevant only if it signals major policy shift — these did not.*
International awards for Indian films/artists	*Relevant only if the award body or the person has UPSC history — none here.*
Technology product launches (phones, apps) without policy angle	*UPSC tests S&T with governance implications, not consumer products.*

These topics consumed significant media space this month. Skipping them is not a gap — it is discipline.

SECTION 4 — QUICK-FIRE FACTS

One-line facts from April 2026. Read once. Revisit before the exam.

1.	Ganga Expressway — 594 km, 12 UP districts, Meerut to Prayagraj, ₹36,000 crore.
2.	UAE exits OPEC/OPEC+ effective May 1, 2026. UAE was OPEC's third-largest producer.
3.	Population Census 2026 commenced April 1 — India's first census since 2011; 16th census overall.
4.	Constitution 131st Amendment Bill proposes Lok Sabha expansion to ~888 seats based on 2011 Census.
5.	India-NZ FTA signed — India's first FTA with a South Pacific OECD nation.
6.	IBCA — New Delhi Declaration proposed; 7 big cat species; 96 member countries.
7.	DPI@2047 roadmap by NITI Aayog — 3-phase digital infrastructure vision for Viksit Bharat.
8.	SCO Defence Ministers' Meeting — Bishkek, Kyrgyzstan, April 28, 2026.
9.	Exercise Pragati — Indian Army exercise with 11 Indian Ocean nations.
10.	Madhya Pradesh forms UCC drafting panel; Uttarakhand remains only state to have implemented UCC.
11.	India's forex reserves: USD 701.4 billion (January 2026) — ~11 months of import cover.
12.	Real GDP growth FY26 estimated at 7.4%; India fastest-growing major economy for 4th consecutive year.
13.	India CPI inflation: average 1.7% (Apr–Dec 2025) — lowest since CPI series began.
14.	RTE Act — Supreme Court directed states to ensure timely admissions under 25% reservation clause.
15.	E-PRAAPTI portal: EPFO's Aadhaar-based portal for tracking inoperative PF accounts.
16.	World Health Day: April 7. Ambedkar Jayanti: April 14. Earth Day: April 22. World Heritage Day: April 18.
17.	Sikkim 50th Statehood celebrations underway — integration with India: May 16, 1975.

18.	Underground coal gasification — emerging technology for energy security; converts coal to syngas in-situ.
19.	NITI Aayog DPI@2047 — Phase 1 (2026-30): livelihoods; Phase 2 (2030-40): productivity; Phase 3 (2040-47): AI-led governance.
20.	Memristor — fourth fundamental circuit element (alongside resistor, capacitor, inductor); applications in neuromorphic computing.

SECTION 5 — MONTHLY SCORECARD

Attempt all 20 questions without referring to notes. Score 16–20: excellent. 11–15: good — revisit Must-Know Exam Focus points. 6–10: revise the Deep Dive topics. Below 6: read the Month at a Glance again, then the Must-Know topics only.

#	Question	Answer
1.	The Ganga Expressway connects: (a) Lucknow to Kanpur (b) Agra to Varanasi (c) Meerut to Prayagraj (d) Delhi to Mathura	**(c)**
2.	Article 81 of the Indian Constitution sets a maximum of how many elected members in the Lok Sabha? (a) 543 (b) 545 (c) 550 (d) 600	**(c) 550**
3.	The 84th Amendment (2001) extended the freeze on Lok Sabha seat reallocation until: (a) 2021 (b) First census after 2026 (c) 2031 (d) First census after 2031	**(b)**
4.	Which country exited OPEC+ effective May 1, 2026? (a) Qatar (b) UAE (c) Kuwait (d) Ecuador	**(b) UAE**
5.	OPEC was founded in: (a) 1955 (b) 1960 (c) 1965 (d) 1973	**(b) 1960**
6.	The International Big Cat Alliance (IBCA) focuses on conservation of how many big cat species? (a) 5 (b) 6 (c) 7 (d) 9	**(c) 7**
7.	India's Strategic Petroleum Reserves have a total capacity of approximately: (a) 2.5 million MT (b) 3.5 million MT (c) 5.33 million MT	**(c) 5.33 million MT**

	(d) 7.5 million MT	
8.	The SCO's Regional Anti-Terrorist Structure (RATS) is headquartered in: (a) Beijing (b) Moscow (c) Tashkent (d) Bishkek	**(c) Tashkent**
9.	DPI@2047 was launched by: (a) Ministry of Electronics and IT (b) RBI (c) NITI Aayog (d) Ministry of Finance	**(c) NITI Aayog**
10.	Uttarakhand's UCC was implemented in which year? (a) 2022 (b) 2023 (c) 2024 (d) 2025	**(c) 2024**
11.	Under Article 44, the Uniform Civil Code is classified as: (a) Fundamental Right (b) Directive Principle of State Policy (c) Fundamental Duty (d) Constitutional Right	**(b)**
12.	India became a full member of the SCO in: (a) 2015 (b) 2016 (c) 2017 (d) 2019	**(c) 2017**
13.	The Ganga Expressway includes an emergency airstrip at: (a) Hardoi (b) Shahjahanpur (c) Unnao (d) Sambhal	**(b) Shahjahanpur**
14.	India's CPI inflation averaged approximately what percentage between April and December 2025? (a) 1.7% (b) 3.2% (c) 4.5% (d) 5.1%	**(a) 1.7%**
15.	Which of these is NOT one of the 7 big cats covered by the IBCA? (a) Snow leopard (b) Puma (c) Clouded leopard (d) Jaguar	**(c) Clouded leopard**

16.	The Census Act under which India's Population Census is conducted was enacted in: (a) 1935 (b) 1948 (c) 1952 (d) 1956	**(b) 1948**
17.	India's real GDP growth for FY26 (2025-26) is estimated at: (a) 6.5% (b) 6.8% (c) 7.4% (d) 8.0%	**(c) 7.4%**
18.	A memristor is described as the fourth fundamental circuit element alongside: (a) Transistor, diode, capacitor (b) Resistor, capacitor, inductor (c) Resistor, transistor, diode (d) Capacitor, inductor, transformer	**(b)**
19.	E-PRAAPTI portal is associated with which organisation? (a) Income Tax Department (b) RBI (c) EPFO (d) SEBI	**(c) EPFO**
20.	New Zealand is a member of which trans-Pacific trade agreement? (a) RCEP (b) CPTPP (c) TPP (Trans-Pacific Partnership) (d) ASEAN FTA	**(b) CPTPP**

SECTION 6 — PREVIOUS MONTH RECALL

These MCQs cover topics from March 2026. Do not re-read the March issue before attempting. Pure retrieval. If you score below 3/5, go back and revise those topics.

30-Day Recall — March 2026 (Must-Know Topics)

Q1. The Rashtriya Vayoshri Yojana provides assistive devices to senior citizens belonging to which income group?

(a) BPL families only

(b) Below ₹15,000/month income

(c) All senior citizens above 60

(d) Only those with disabilities

Answer: (a) BPL families only

Q2. Which Article of the Indian Constitution deals with the Finance Commission?

(a) Article 264

(b) Article 269

(c) Article 280

(d) Article 292

Answer: (c) Article 280

Q3. The National Quantum Mission (NQM) aims to develop quantum computers with how many physical qubits by 2031?

(a) 50–100

(b) 50–1000

(c) 500–1000

(d) 1000–2000

Answer: (b) 50–1000 physical qubits

Q4. Biosphere Reserves in India are classified under which body's framework?

(a) IUCN

(b) UNESCO

(c) CITES

(d) CBD

Answer: (b) UNESCO

Q5. Which of these is classified under Schedule IV of the Wildlife Protection Act, 1972 — afforded least protection?

(a) Tiger

(b) Indian Roller

(c) Snow Leopard

(d) One-horned Rhinoceros

Answer: (b) Indian Roller

SECTION 7 — STILLNESS CORNER

THIS MONTH'S FOCUS: Exam Anxiety Is a Signal, Not a Problem

With UPSC 2026 Prelims approximately 6 weeks away, most aspirants are experiencing a familiar pressure. The feeling that you have not done enough. That there is too much left to cover. That others are better prepared. This is not a unique problem — it is the same experience felt by every competitive exam candidate, including those who cleared Prelims last year.

The Neti Neti principle has something useful here. Just as the philosophy strips away the non-essential to find what is real, preparation in these final weeks requires letting go of the anxiety about what you have not done and focusing on what is actually in front of you. The question is not 'Have I covered everything?' The question is 'What do I know well enough to answer confidently?' Work from that foundation outward.

A practical note: sleep deprivation in the last 2 weeks before an exam does not improve performance — it consistently harms recall. If you are currently sleeping fewer than 6 hours, that is your most urgent preparation problem, not your notes.

The exam will test what you understand, not what you have memorised under stress. Prepare accordingly.

4-7-8 Breathing: Inhale for 4 counts. Hold for 7. Exhale for 8. Three cycles before each study session.